

Name: Drill #71 – Win It, Keep It

Category: Transition

Primary Focus: Immediate transition after winning possession

Secondary Focus: First touch, possession, communication, speed of play

Objective

Train players to react instantly after winning the ball. Instead of simply clearing it, players must secure possession, make smart decisions, and capitalize on the brief moment when the opponent is disorganized.

This drill teaches one of the most important principles in soccer:

The first five seconds after winning possession often determine whether you create a scoring opportunity or lose the ball again.

Age Group

- U16–College
 - Ideal for High School Varsity
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Number of Players

Ideal: 12

Works well with:

- 10–16 field players
 - Add goalkeepers as neutral players if desired
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Equipment

- 20–30 cones
- 2 colors of pinnies
- 8–12 soccer balls

- Stopwatch
 - Two small goals (optional)
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Playing Area

Approximately **35 x 30 yards**

Adjust size:

- Better players → smaller field
 - Less experienced players → larger field
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Setup

Play 6v6 inside the grid.

Coach stands outside with spare balls.

Rules

Normal possession game.

The objective is **not** to score immediately.

Instead:

- Complete passes to earn points.
- Teams must transition quickly after winning possession.

Scoring

- Win possession = 1 point
- Complete five consecutive passes = 2 points
- Ten consecutive passes = 3 points

If possession is lost...

Everything resets.

Transition Rule

This is what makes the drill special.

The moment a team wins the ball:

A stopwatch begins.

The team has **five seconds** to complete:

- First controlled touch
- First pass
- Second pass

If they panic and lose possession...

No points.

Players quickly realize that winning the ball is only half the job.

Keeping it is equally important.

Coaching Emphasis

Immediately after winning possession

Ask players:

- Can we play forward?
- If not...
- Can we keep possession?

Teach players NOT to force passes.

Coaching Points

1. First Touch

Must be away from pressure.

Not toward defenders.

Excellent first touch creates time.

2. Head Up

Players should scan **before** receiving.

Encourage:

"Check your shoulder."

Every few seconds.

3. Support Angles

Nearest teammates move immediately.

Never stand still.

Create:

- triangles
 - diamonds
 - passing lanes
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4. Communication

Encourage constant talk.

Examples:

- Turn!
 - Time!
 - One touch!
 - Man on!
 - Switch!
 - Back!
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5. Width

Immediately stretch the field.

Winning teams often stay too compact.

Open space.

6. Speed of Play

Move the ball faster than defenders can recover.

One-touch when possible.

Two-touch when necessary.

Never three touches unless required.

Common Mistakes

Panic Clearance

Player wins ball...

Immediately kicks it away.

Correction:

Ask:

"Who has possession now?"

Everyone Runs Forward

Huge mistake.

No passing options remain.

Correction:

One player checks.

One stretches.

One supports.

Standing Still

After passing...

Player watches.

Correction:

Pass...

Move immediately.

Poor First Touch

Heavy touch.

Ball lost.

Correction:

Receive across body.

Protect ball.

Progressions

Progression 1

Limit players to:

Two touches.

Progression 2

One-touch only.

Excellent challenge.

Progression 3

Shrink field.

Pressure increases.

Progression 4

Add neutral player.

Creates overload.

Progression 5

Add two mini goals.

Now after five passes...

Team may attack.

This creates realistic transitions.

Regression

Allow unlimited touches.

Increase field size.

Remove pass requirement.

Physical Demands

High aerobic.

Repeated accelerations.

Constant changes of direction.

Game realistic.

Tactical Concepts

Players learn:

- Counter-press resistance
- Possession after recovery

- Switching play
- Supporting angles
- Playing out of pressure
- Decision making